

KF15 Expanded Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23-24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

Returning a gift for a gift received is an essential practice that supports our healing. Giving and receiving gifts is healthy karis circulation. Karis Fellowships is a gift from God and from volunteers—a gift to you. These volunteers offer their gifts of service and finances in response to what God has done for them through Karis Fellowships. Please join with us by circulating your gifts. You can make a regular automatic donation to KF through the **Give a Gift** button on the KF website.

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

In this lesson we begin looking at KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

In KF, we teach mindfulness exercises that we ourselves have found helpful, but there are many other options out there that you might try. When life’s experiments trigger judgment and wrath, you need to be skilled in mindfulness, so take time to train, if not every day, then regularly. See if you can work up to spending twenty minutes, twice each day, in mindfulness practice and meditation. If you are raising young children, you might want to take small breaks throughout the day to explore mindfulness together. You can invite your children to join you in short times of practice. Teach them to simply notice their breath for one minute, and then see what happens.

The **Mercy Meditation** supports our efforts to reorient the misdirected energy described in KF Confession 4.¹ With the addition of this meditation, you will have four different practices available to you. Explore the same meditation for a whole month to give you time to discover whether it works for you. Or you might practice each of the four meditations for five minutes, giving you twenty minutes of meditation practice.

By practicing mindfulness, you bring your mind and emotions under the guidance of your own will. You are then free to connect to the Holy Spirit in a moment. Undisciplined minds are like wayward and unruly puppies jumping at every opportunity to impose their own primitive wills. Puppies are big enough to do damage and, like all beginners, are in desperate need of training. Your mind and emotions also need

training, just like those puppies. Be kind to yourself during this process, and remember that there are seasons of effort and seasons of rest.

The Mercy Meditation

Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. You might wish to take some notes in your KF journal. *(Pause)* Draw your mind away from the events of the day, from the past or the future, and from others. Focus on what is happening inside your skin. Settle into being present and aware in this moment. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

And now, reflect for thirty seconds on each of the following three questions. Observe your feelings and thoughts without judgment, and notice your body's reactions.

1. In what areas am I most critical of myself? *(Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause, and if you haven't already done so, take thirty seconds to jot down your thoughts. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

2. For what do I need to forgive myself? *(Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause. You might make a note of what came to mind. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

3. How do I treat myself when I make a mistake? *(Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

Pause, and if you wish, write for thirty seconds. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Now experiment with bringing compassion to yourself in some way. For example, call to mind someone who loves you just as you are. This might be someone divine, like God or Jesus, or perhaps someone mortal and human. You might call to mind one of God's other creatures. *(Pause)* Imagine seeing yourself through their eyes. You might give yourself an appreciative hug. *(Pause)* However you choose to bring compassion to yourself, just observe and rest for one minute. Practice letting go of judgment and breathe. *(Pause for 1 minute)*

And pause. In this practice, we plant seeds of mercy—not only for ourselves but for others. Mercy is the civil law of God's kingdom.²

Our hymn for this lesson is *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross*. This is one of 750 hymns written by Isaac Watts, many of which we still sing today. Isaac Watts was an evangelical non-conformist Christian in seventeenth century England. Both he and his father were excluded from the established church and from any government position, and Isaac's father spent years in prison for his Christian convictions.

Let's listen to our hymn.

When I survey the wondrous cross
On which the Prince of Glory died,
My richest gain I count but loss,
And pour contempt on all my pride.³

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

I hope that you have a **Shoulds Worksheet** in front of you as we explore KF Confession 4 together. This Confession reminds us that when we are misoriented, we judge ourselves and others with contempt and feel justified in our wrath. I find this Confession rather painful. Judging does so much damage—to ourselves, to others, and to God’s purposes in this world. Our judgments are the main obstacles to our growth and development, and those judgments inevitably undermine the growth of others.

We are all deeply wounded from past trauma that we have judged as bad or evil. As a result, we dare not go forward into uncharted territory for fear of encountering more trauma. We are afraid of not having the right answers or not making the right choices. We are afraid that it is too late. We are afraid because we imagine that trying something new can only result in judgment and pain. We are not willing to grow into greater understanding because we are afraid that we might look back on our immaturity with self-hate and be appalled at the damage we have caused by choosing so much misorientation. All of this is scary unless we remember that we now have the tools to deal with our fear and self-hate.

Paul’s letter to the Galatians reminds us that while striving to become like Jesus, we sometimes experience intense self-hate because we have inadvertently adopted an additional set of standards by which we measure and mercilessly judge ourselves. We may hate ourselves for having resisted so great a salvation, with all of its potential and delight. We may also blame ourselves for having waited so long to grow, for not taking a courageous step, or for refusing our true potential. Perhaps we think that we should have it all figured out by now. If we face our self-contempt, what will happen to us? The only response to self-contempt that we understand right now is judgment and self-condemnation. Without KF training, we are powerless against the self-hate which lurks within us, ready to leap upon us in full fury if we give any thought to the possibility of real glory. We know that our Idol will punish us if we try to break free of our enslavement to its dreams of idealized glory, so it’s no surprise that people drop out of Karis Fellowships at this stage in their training. Let’s admit that tackling the Idol Self is very difficult work. We must be able to endure the pain of our self-hate as we press on to restore what we have lost. Our KF tools help us to courageously endure moments of self-hate while we grow.

Self-hate and self-contempt are major motivators in the lives of most people. Many of us live in a country ruled by judgment and criticism, where the secret police of shoulds and claims controls us with the threat of torturing self-hate. But like emigrants, you are leaving that country and going to a new world where there is now no condemnation in Christ Jesus.⁴ I would like to encourage you with this: as you give up your search for the *Glory of Me!*, you will look back with compassion on your former life of striving, and you will experience increasing gratitude to God for His patience and love in supporting you while you find your way home.

Shoulds and taboos are the artificial internal motivators of the Idol. They are the legal systems, or law, that we use to motivate ourselves and to impose our will on others. Externalized shoulds express themselves in two different ways: we either try to force others to conform to our standards, or we believe that others are forcing their standards on us. These standards that we think others are imposing on us are often standards that we are imposing on ourselves. When others do not fulfill our shoulds, we feel toward them all the fury that we unconsciously feel toward ourselves; and when others appear to impose their shoulds on us, we feel compelled to comply with them, resist them, or fight them. Externalized shoulds explain why we need to impose our will on others and, also, why we feel so much judgment from others.

We assume that others are judging us with the same wrath with which we judge ourselves. God lovingly gave us the Ten Commandments, but we have imposed upon ourselves ten gazillion other commandments in the form of claims and shoulds.

The long temper of love gives us time to think instead of mindlessly indulging in the luxury of effortless judgment. If we think rather than judge, we can objectively observe the story that we are using to justify our judgment. The **Shoulds Worksheet** helps us identify our misoriented emotions, untangle the rationale behind our judgments, and heal the underlying fear. Let's imagine the story of a wife and mother who meets with a disappointment. She instantly judges the event as evil but is not aware of doing so. Her judgment requires a story that will generate the misoriented emotions that she needs to propel herself forward on her idealized path. She must focus on the most painful bits of her present and her past in order to construct a story that is convincing enough to justify her judgment and inordinate emotions. All the positive aspects of the situation are discounted or simply dismissed. The story must restore her pride in her rightness and validate her choice to punish herself and others. Self-pity, disappointment, anger, and despair all come pouring in and, of course, irritability toward her spouse and children. Her judgments prevent her from entering a creative, teachable place. Until she gives up her judgments, she cannot be mindful of the realities of the situation, nor can she be grateful to God for all of His mercies.

Let's look at Part Two of our **Shoulds Worksheet**. One KF member observed that we are not looking deeply for spiritual insight here. We are looking deeply at how crazy we are!

Part Two: Looking Deeply

1. Recognize the "mistake"

Ask yourself: *What did I do that was "wrong" or has caused my discomfort?* Here are some examples of how you might answer this question: *I said this thing and another person reacted negatively . . . I messed up my interview and lost that job opportunity . . . I allowed that organization to impose their ideas on me . . . I wasn't strong enough to follow through . . . I can't make any friends.*

This is how one KF member answered this question: "I believed that I should be able to accomplish anything, regardless of realities. I believed that limitations should not affect me—I should be above my background and all of its wounding, above the limitations of those around me, and above the realities of money, abilities, time, or health. I imagined that I could even defy God's laws and get away with it. In other words, for me, it was wrong to have limitations."

Now let me tell you about two doctors who handle their limitations and neurotic self-hate in different but equally misoriented ways. The first doctor feels discouragement when he can't help someone. Although he is successful and helps the vast majority of the people he sees, he focuses on the few he cannot help. He believes that he should be able to help *everyone, all* of the time; it is *wrong* that he cannot help everyone. The second doctor is also successful, but he too is unable to help everyone all of the time. He deals with this limitation by dismissing as insignificant those he cannot help. To save his neurotic pride, he believes that he can help everyone and, therefore, thinks that he does help everyone. For him, those who are not helped are just unresponsive idiots. In his mind, it is *wrong* that he cannot help everyone, so he has to make up a story to justify his limitation.

2. Write down your shoulds

Should-statements often begin with should-phrases, such as *I should always, I should never, I should be able to, I should feel, and I should know*. On this worksheet I have given you a number of examples

of how you might finish these phrases. Here is how a KF member finished one of his should-phrases: "I am committed to the idea that I should always be able to manage my limitations so that nothing and no one can interfere with any of my plans."

Our capacity to invent shoulds for ourselves seems to be without limits. For example, we might believe that we should be able to make someone love us or take care of us; or perhaps we believe that we should be able to fend off all the bothersome aspects of relationships and life. Using the suggestions on the worksheet as a guide, write down some of your own should-statements.

3. Define perfection according to your Idol

When you write this statement, you can have a little fun describing the extremes of perfection to which you aspire. Sometimes it's helpful to see how crazy our dreams of glory can be, and smile. These extreme statements will give you an insight into your pride system. They tend to include words like *already*, *everyone*, *always*, *best*, *never*, and *more*. Here is an example: "I should *already* be able to control *everyone* so that I *always* experience what I think is *best* and *never* have to feel that only *more* would be enough." You can, of course, be more specific.

4. Identify your limitations

In this step, we deal with the real limitations of being material creatures living in a misoriented world. Our limitations will be similar to those experienced by others, and if we are mindful, we might even feel closer to the rest of humanity, which is subject to the same limitations. By getting back into the realm of mere mortals, we can let go of living in our own little egocentric world. You might think about the limitations that God's logos imposes on you personally—limitations like honesty, purity, honor, and trustworthiness. You cannot expect outcomes that are productive and healthy if you lie, practice addictive behaviors, dishonor your own or another's body, and live chaotically—disrespecting God, others, and yourself. So, what are your limitations?

Try working through the second part of the **Shoulds Worksheet** this week to help you discover where you are today. You can rejoice in the knowledge of that truth. In order to get where you want to be, you have to know where you are right now. Recognizing the truth about yourself sets you on the path to freedom.

The first two parts of the worksheet help you acknowledge where you are. It's a kind of confession. Next week, we will look at our recovery from the misorientation created by our shoulds. Because we have a Savior by our side, we can courageously look into the mirror of the logos and endure the fear and judgment that a conscious and accurate assessment of ourselves may bring. By doing this worksheet, we strike a blow at our illusions and our pride.

Notice when you are using the words *should* and *shouldn't* in your thinking and conversation. Those words can reveal the *thou shalt*s and *thou shalt not*s that you have created to support your Idol Self. You might try this trick: *When you notice that you are using the word **should**, try replacing it with the word **could** or **might**. (Repeat)* See what happens. I learned that trick from my husband a long time ago, and it has helped me recognize my shoulds. You might try it for yourself.

Our prayer could go something like this:

Merciful God, help me let go of my shoulds. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?”)

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

This is KF Confession 4:

We judged ourselves and others with contempt and felt justified in our wrath.

Let’s turn to the Gospel of Luke, chapter 6.

Perhaps by now you have scheduled a regular time to practice your KF tools. During that time, you might explore a **Shoulds Worksheet**. To help you identify your own particular shoulds, review chapter 3 of *Neurosis and Human Growth* and the chapters that describe your Idol.⁵ You might make a running list of the shoulds that you have discovered in your own life and then see how that list changes during your KF training. Notice that I am not saying that you *should* do any of these things. I’m just reminding you of a few things that you *might* do during your KF time to help you achieve the oriented outcomes that you desire. In the months ahead, you can review all of these tools, especially when extra training is offered. We hope that using the tools will become part of your soul-care routine. You are a creature in time and have all the time you need to grow. How does that feel? You have all the time you need to grow. I think that feels pretty good.

Here is my translation of **Luke 6:41–42**, a passage that is probably quite familiar to many of you:

⁴¹Why do you regard the twig that is in your sibling's eye, but do not fully observe the beam that is in your own eye? ⁴²Or how can you say to your sibling, “Sibling, allow me to take out the twig that is in your eye,” when you yourself do not see the beam that is in your own eye? You pretender! First take the beam out of your own eye, and then you will see straight in order to take out the twig that is in your sibling's eye.

Take a deep breath.

Unfortunately for our Idol, we can’t always do what we think we should, so when we can’t do something perfectly, we might try to find satisfaction and security by making someone else do it for us. Our illusion is that if we can make someone else fulfill our shoulds, we will feel better about ourselves. We believe that if people would be what we want them to be and do what we want them to do, we would be able to relieve our anxiety and achieve our goals. Whenever we want others to do things our way, we have already judged that their way is wrong based on our righteous and omniscient wisdom. Our judgment is often the externalization of unachieved standards that we have imposed on ourselves. We desperately want others to fulfill those standards for us because we imagine that their compliance will stop our self-hate; we hope that changing them will take us effortlessly into our imagined glory. If we are particularly forceful and effective in getting them to do what we think they should do, we are fooled into believing that we have solved the problem of our basic anxiety and found a path to glory.

When others fail to accommodate us and our way of doing things, we are short-tempered and feel betrayed. Although we might keep our mouths shut, which is a great start, we are still reacting in our minds and bodies. We only notice “their problem” and fail to notice our own. In our shortsightedness, we

really do think that we are qualified to judge and to fix others. Our pride tells us that we know how others should live—and that's how we end up in other people's business.

This metaphor of twigs and beams is about the relative importance of our business and another person's business, and it reflects the problem of our misoriented perspective. When we impose our legal systems on other people, our perspective becomes distorted, and we start focusing on their business rather than taking care of our own. Instead of changing ourselves, we try to fix or change them. Fixing others feels easier and is less threatening to our Idol because when we try to fix others, we are re-enforcing our pride system rather than taking it apart. In this metaphor, Jesus uses the Greek word for a construction beam—something that we build with. These beams support the temple of our Idol Self, but this temple is so vulnerable that we need others to validate it by accommodating our pride system. We may be able to force others to comply with our shoulds, but in doing so we must steal from them the resources they have been given for dealing with their own Idol's temple. However, most people will not participate in our search for glory. They see things differently. They are not interested in maintaining the scaffold that our Idol has erected to shore up its tottering temple. What in our eyes has the importance of a structural beam is a mere twig in someone else's eyes. Other people cannot possibly understand how important our beam is to us.

What we don't understand and refuse to explore is how our problems with other people are mercifully exposing the tyranny of our shoulds and self-hate. We try to avoid that humbling exposure by employing the same forceful, manipulative tactics that we have always used to make others support our Idol's pride. We might get compliance from others in the moment, but we damage the long-term possibilities for relationship. When we impose our shoulds on someone else, we avoid the painful process of removing the beam in our own eye, which means actively demolishing our Idol's temple. Forcing others to comply provides an escape from the hard work of learning to love. Any situation can seem to have a twig in its eye—our bodies, our church, our jobs, politics, an obstacle, a frustration, a relationship, or any uncomfortable situation. Those twigs that we see in another's eye are often our own beams reflected from afar. We see in another what is actually within ourselves. It's a problem of perspective and interpretation.

Your feelings of discomfort and your fear of self-hate are used by the Idol to justify your clumsy efforts to remove the twig in someone else's eye. No wonder people don't trust you! Have you noticed that when you try to fix other people, whether actively or in your own mind, the focus goes outside your own skin and into someone else's business? This is why getting into other people's business is so dangerous and even rather stupid; you are not motivated by the truth about the situation but driven by the compelling need to keep the beams of your Idol's temple securely in place. If you have strong feelings about others and find yourself making misoriented choices, you really need to work on your business first by removing the beam in your own eye. Then you might have something to offer that will support others as they work on their business. If you stick to your own business, they might actually trust you with their eyes. It takes a long time for people to trust another person, and you will need the very long temper of love to earn that trust.

If you want to be real and express the love of God, you must give up imposing your shoulds on others and on yourself. Go back to the list **Love or Pride?** Is your attitude and behavior in line with love?

Once you know your own business, you can ignore everything else. Isn't that amazing? You don't even have to think about it. That's a wonderful freedom, so I continue learning to mind my own business in new areas of my life. My problem is that I want to think about everything else and everyone else so that I

can avoid my business. Most of us have spent our whole lives avoiding our business. You may be asking right now: *What is my business?*⁶ Your trustworthiness and your healing are your business. Your fear is also your business—and so is your true glory.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord, help me stick to my business. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?”)

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume a meditation posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider a twig in someone else’s eye, something that you would like to fix. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

(Choose from this section a few phrases that are meaningful to you)

Feelings

As you *consider a twig in someone else’s eye, something that you would like to fix*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* You can learn to recognize and honor your feelings without allowing them to master you. Recognize with compassion whatever you may be experiencing, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush our real feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider a twig in someone else’s eye. (Pause)* Feelings and passing thoughts are not right or wrong; they just are. Give yourself permission now to explore them without judgment, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Breathe, and bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider that twig in someone else’s eye*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what frustration or vindictive triumph feels like in your body, or perhaps what anxiety or hurt pride feels like. *(Pause)* If your sensations are uncomfortable, you can move your attention to an area of your body that is not reacting, and rest. When you are ready, return to respectfully observe those uncomfortable sensations. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider a twig in someone else's eye*. Isn't it wonderful that He will consider that twig with you? *(Pause)* Have you judged the twig as good or evil? What are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Is this judgment a regular pattern in your life? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—perhaps of others or of the loss of your hope for glory? Are avoiding your own business or your True Self? Observe your responses as just information, and breathe a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created you to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered fixing someone else*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Feelings are just chemical reactions in your body bringing you information. With training, you can choose what you will do with those feelings. *(Pause)* When a fear or judgment signals you through the body, you can focus on your body and your breath rather than getting caught up in a story and reacting. Breathe with compassion for yourself and for others who long to fix another person, and help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?")

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

We are so grateful that it is Your loving intention to train us for our true glory. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You continue to guide us to the truth of who You created us to be and what You want us to do. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?")

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ www.livingmindfully.org. The Mercy Meditation has been resourced from Mindful Living and adapted for Karis Fellowships by Nancy Diven.

² James 2:12–13.

³ *When I Survey the Wondrous Cross* by Isaac Watts (1674–1748), youtu.be/U-hz6L6LAug.

⁴ Rom. 8:1.

⁵ Karen Horney, *Neurosis and Human Growth* (New York: Norton, 1991).

⁶ See KF11.